Within the BJP, the Advani–Sushma group was now labelled the ‘160–180 club’—those who believed that the BJP could not cross a certain threshold in a general election. Their calculation was that with a maximum of 180 seats (the BJP’s best-ever performance had been 182 seats in 1999 in the aftermath of the Kargil elections), a Modi-led BJP would not be able to get allies and the party would be forced to look for an alternative leadership.

The Modi camp had their own numerical counter. ‘Mission 272-plus’ became the new buzzword, signifying a desire to win a clear majority in the general elections. Modi is partial to sharp, catchy slogans. When his aides came up with Mission 272 as the goal for 2014, he added the ‘plus’ word. ‘We must think positive. The more we aim for, the more we will get!’ he told his team.

Some of his supporters were more modest, looking at 200 plus as their initial aim. ‘Once we cross 200, we will get a rush of allies,’ was Jaitley’s view. The 272-plus number, though, had been pasted on the war room of Team Modi in Gandhinagar. The run chase was about to begin.

A key member of this Team Modi was Prashant Kishore, a young US-trained public health professional. I met the thirty-six-year-old Bihar-born Kishore to get under the skin of the Modi campaign. He told me he had been the head of a UN mission in Africa and was working on a UN project on malnutrition when he visited Gujarat for the first time for fieldwork in early 2011. ‘I guess it was a case of instant attraction because the chief minister told me he wanted me in his team and I readily agreed,’ he says.

Kishore was a policy strategist with a passion for technology and statistical data. His tasks were well defined—build a crack team of back-room boys who would take the Modi campaign to another level by staging high-profile events. The team’s first major election event was the 3D campaign in the 2012 Gujarat assembly elections (see chapter 9 for more). The 2012 assembly elections, in fact, would serve as a trailer in many ways for the general election campaign to follow. ‘We first commissioned detailed surveys for the Gujarat assembly elections in mid-2012 and then